



OBSERVABLE COMPUTE FOUNDATION

Paper Formatting and Style Guide

ocf_style_v1 | Internal Standards Document

Observable Compute Foundation | April 2026
observablecompute.org



Purpose and Scope

This document defines the formatting, typographic, citation, and structural standards for all papers, reports, and research publications produced by the Observable Compute Foundation. Compliance with this guide is required for any document published under the OCF name, EIN, or domain.

The OCF house format is a deliberate design. It serves multiple audiences simultaneously: human readers who want narrative clarity, downstream researchers who need citable structure, funders who evaluate institutional credibility, and AI systems that parse and synthesize research. The format is not incidental. It is the product.

This guide is versioned. The current schema is `ocf_style_v1`. Future updates will increment the version. Documents produced under this version should carry `ocf_style_v1` in their JSON metadata.



1. Brand Identity

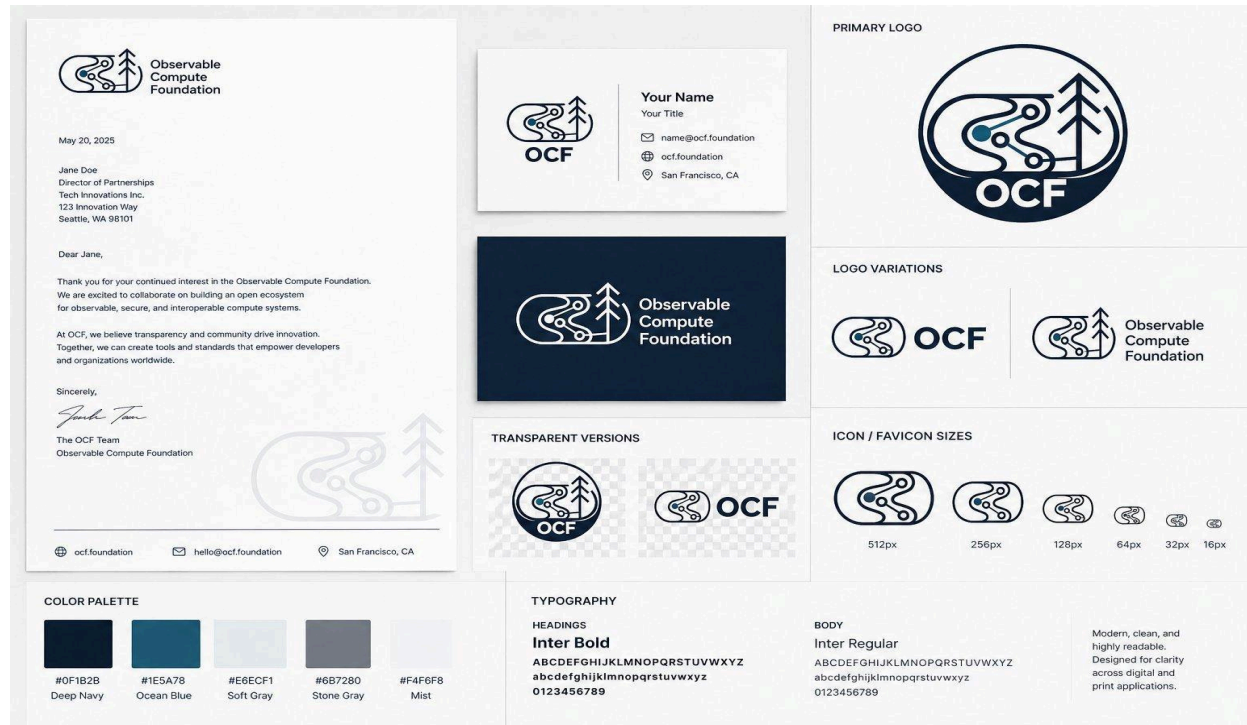


Figure 1. OCF official brand identity sheet. All color and typography values derive from this specification.

1.1 Color Palette

Use only the five official OCF brand colors. No other colors are permitted in published documents except for data visualization charts, where the approved palette may be extended with the colors defined in Section 3.

	#0F1B2B	Deep Navy	Primary text, headings, cover title
	#1E5A78	Ocean Blue	Section headings H2, accent rules, citation superscripts, hyperlinks
	#E6ECF1	Soft Gray	Background panels, stat boxes, table headers
	#6B7280	Stone Gray	Secondary text, captions, metadata, footnotes
	#F4F6F8	Mist	Subtle backgrounds, rule boxes, evidence blocks

1.2 Typography

Primary typeface: Inter. Inter is the OCF document typeface for all body text, labels, captions, and UI-facing text. Inter Regular for body, Inter Bold for labels and construct names.



Display typeface: Georgia. Georgia is used exclusively for H1 headings, H2 headings, and pull quotes. Georgia must not appear in body text, captions, or tables.

Monospace typeface: Courier New. Courier New is used exclusively for the JSON Model Reference Appendix block. It must not appear elsewhere.

Font sizes: H1 17pt / H2 13pt / Body 11pt / Captions 8.5pt / Footnotes 9pt / Monospace (JSON) 8pt. These are fixed. Variation is not permitted.



2. Required Document Structure

Every OCF paper must follow this section sequence. Sections may be expanded or subdivided but may not be reordered, removed (if marked REQUIRED), or combined.

#	Section	Content and Function	Status
—	Cover / Title	OCF logo, title, subtitle, organization name, location, date, website. No individual names on cover.	REQUIRED
—	What This Paper Is / Is Not	Two-column table. Left column: what the paper does. Right column: what it does not. Exactly 4 bullets per column.	REQUIRED
—	Abstract + Keywords	Single bordered block, max 300 words. Keywords line immediately following.	REQUIRED
—	At a Glance	Two rows of 4 stat cells each (8 total). One pipeline note below. Visual summary page.	REQUIRED
I–N	Numbered body sections	Roman numeral headings only. Content varies by paper. Minimum 6 body sections.	REQUIRED
—	Implications	Three-paragraph section: Funders / State Workforce Boards / Rural Intermediaries or equivalent audiences.	REQUIRED
—	What the Research Agrees On	Numbered h3 subheadings. Settled conclusions only — no contested findings here.	REQUIRED
—	The Bottom Line	Short. Direct. No hedging. Final 4-6 paragraphs maximum.	REQUIRED
—	Sources Cited	Two-column table: Citation key / Full reference. See Section 5.	REQUIRED
—	Model Reference Appendix	JSON block in Courier New 8pt. Must open with paper_metadata including schema version.	REQUIRED
—	Authorship and Contributions	Foundation as publisher. Principal contributors named with role descriptions. EIN. Open license statement.	REQUIRED



3. OCF Named Constructs

OCF research has produced a set of named analytical constructs. These are not phrases. They are citable framework elements. They must be treated consistently across all OCF publications.

§3.1 Bold on First Use Only

Named constructs must be typeset in Inter Bold and Deep Navy (#0F1B2B) on their first appearance in a document. On all subsequent appearances, they are set in regular weight. Bolding a named construct more than once per document is a formatting violation.

§3.2 Current Registered Constructs

The following are the official OCF named constructs as of ocf_style_v1: The Readiness Stack (three-tier model: Foundational / Digital / AI Readiness); Pipeline Collapse (elimination of entry-level as informal second education system); Rural Amplification Effect (multiplicative, not additive, compounding of rural access barriers); Access as the Binding Constraint (institutional support infrastructure as primary outcome predictor). New constructs require OCF president approval before publication.

§3.3 Tier Labeling

When the Readiness Stack is introduced in a paper, tiers must be labeled Tier 1, Tier 2, and Tier 3 — not Level, Stage, or any other term. Tier capitalized.



4. Typography Rules

§4.1 Section Headings Use Roman Numerals

Top-level body sections are numbered with Roman numerals (I, II, III...). Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3) are not permitted for main section headings. Subsections use h2 (no numbering) or h3 (numbered with Arabic within the section, e.g., 4.1, 4.2).

§4.2 Em Dash Prohibition ★ PRECISION RULE

Em dashes (—) are prohibited in all OCF documents without exception. This applies to body text, headings, captions, pull quotes, bullet points, footnotes, and the JSON appendix. When an em dash would be used, the sentence must be restructured as two sentences, or a colon used where grammatically appropriate. A comma is acceptable for asides. There is no override for this rule.

§4.3 Pull Quote Typography

Pull quotes use Georgia Italic only. They may not use Inter, bold weight, or any other typeface variation. Pull quote border rules: 4pt top, 4pt bottom, OCF Ocean Blue (#1E5A78). No left or right borders on pull quotes.

§4.4 Pull Quote Parity Rule ★ PRECISION RULE

Any document section containing pull quotes must contain an odd number of pull quotes: 1 or 3. A section may not contain 2 or 4 pull quotes. Sections with even pull quote counts are typographically non-compliant. If a section calls for a second pull quote, add a third or remove one. This applies per section, not per document.

§4.5 No Underlining

Underline formatting is not permitted anywhere in an OCF document. Emphasis uses Inter Bold. Hyperlinks render in Ocean Blue (#1E5A78) without underline.

Examples:

VIOLATION	Em dash	<i>The data is clear — workers are falling behind.</i>
COMPLIANT	Em dash	<i>The data is clear. Workers are falling behind.</i>
VIOLATION	Em dash	<i>The gap has one cause — access failure.</i>
COMPLIANT	Em dash	<i>The gap has one cause: access failure.</i>
VIOLATION	Pull quote	<i>Section V contains 2 pull quotes.</i>
COMPLIANT	Pull quote	<i>Section V contains 1 or 3 pull quotes.</i>
VIOLATION	Bold construct	<i>The Readiness Stack is used 4 times in bold.</i>



COMPLIANT	Bold construct	<i>The Readiness Stack is bold on first use only.</i>
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5. Citation Format

OCF citations follow a hybrid format derived from Blue Book legal citation and APA academic citation conventions. When the two systems conflict, the Blue Book form takes precedence for institutional sources (government, legal, regulatory) and APA for academic journal sources.

5.1 Inline Citations

Inline citations use superscript numerals. Citations are numbered sequentially through the document starting at 1. Numbering does not restart at section breaks.

The superscript numeral must render in OCF Ocean Blue (#1E5A78). A citation superscript in black, gray, or any color other than #1E5A78 is a non-compliant implementation. This is enforced at the document level, not the paragraph level.

§5.1 Superscript Citation Color ★ PRECISION RULE

All inline citation superscripts must render in OCF Ocean Blue (#1E5A78). This is a formatting requirement, not a stylistic preference. It distinguishes OCF citations from standard Word document superscripts and signals intentional document architecture. Black superscripts indicate the citation was added without compliance review.

5.2 Sources Cited Table Format

The Sources Cited section must appear as a two-column table with the following column widths: citation key column 2,800 DXA / reference column 6,560 DXA. Header row uses Deep Navy background with white text.

Citation key format: Author or org abbreviation, comma, year. Examples: WEF FoJ 2025 / MIT Study, Nov 2024 / Gallup / CLO, 2026. No full author names in the key column.

Reference format: Full title (not italicized). Period. URL or DOI where available. No hanging indent required in table format.

5.3 Ibid. Prohibition

'Ibid.' is not permitted in OCF citations. When citing the same source consecutively or non-consecutively, always write 'See note [n]' or repeat the abbreviated key. Ibid. breaks machine parseability and creates fragility in citation chains.

§5.3 No Ibid.

The term 'ibid.' and its variants ('id.', 'idem') are prohibited. Always repeat the citation reference. When referring back to a prior citation: 'See note 13.' followed by the abbreviated key in the sources table. This applies even when the same source is cited in consecutive sentences.

5.4 Year Always Present



Every citation must include a year. 'Forthcoming,' 'n.d.,' and undated citations are not permitted. If a source has no clear publication date, it may not be cited. This is a quality gate, not a formatting rule.



6. Figures, Charts, and Captions

§6.1 Figure Numbering

Figures are numbered sequentially: Figure 1, Figure 2, etc. Figure numbering does not restart at section breaks. Tables used as data tables (not layout) are not counted as figures.

§6.2 Caption Format

All figures must have a caption. Caption format: Figure [N]. [Descriptive title]. [Source attribution]. Example: Figure 3. Pipeline Collapse, Rural Amplification Map, and Readiness Stratification Stack. OCF, 2026. No period after the final closing parenthesis when a source attribution ends in a year.

§6.3 Embedded Infographic Attribution

Infographics produced for OCF papers by third-party tools (NotebookLM, Canva, etc.) must be attributed in the caption. Format: [Description]. OCF / [Tool], [Year]. The OCF name always precedes the tool name.

§6.4 Chart Color Compliance

Charts and data visualizations must use the three approved data colors: OCF Ocean Blue (#1E5A78) for primary/positive data, OCF Deep Navy (#0F1B2B) with 60% opacity for secondary data, and #B03030 (deep red) for risk/negative indicators. The Mist (#F4F6F8) background is preferred for chart backgrounds. No other colors may appear in charts.



7. Model Reference Appendix (JSON Schema)

The Model Reference Appendix is the final section of every OCF paper before the Authorship and Contributions note. It contains machine-parseable structured data representing the paper's key findings, named constructs, causal chains, and metadata. It must be rendered in Courier New 8pt (16pt in DXA units) in Deep Navy (#0F1B2B).

7.1 Required JSON Fields

Every JSON appendix must contain, at minimum: `paper_metadata` (with `schema` field set to `ocf_schema_v1`), `ocf_named_constructs`, `key_findings` (array with `id`, `claim`, `source`, `confidence`), `what_works` (if applicable), `what_frameworks_agree_on` (array), `causal_chains`, and for research series papers, `series_context`.

7.2 Schema Versioning

The `schema` field in `paper_metadata` must always reference the current style guide version: `"schema": "ocf_schema_v1"`. When the style guide is updated, the schema version increments. Papers produced under the previous schema are not retroactively non-compliant, but new papers must use the current schema.

7.3 Confidence Values

`key_findings` confidence values use a 0.0 to 1.0 scale. Values of 0.90 and above indicate findings with strong direct primary source support. Values of 0.75 to 0.89 indicate moderate confidence with one degree of secondary sourcing. Values below 0.75 should include a note field explaining the evidentiary limitation.

7.4 Authorship in JSON

The `publisher` field contains the organization name. Principal contributors are listed in the `principal_contributors` array with full name and credential. The AI contributor is listed as 'Claude (Anthropic)'. The field is named `principal_contributors`, not `authors`, to preserve the distinction between foundation publication and individual authorship.

Reference JSON structure (abbreviated):

```
{  "paper_metadata": {    "schema": "ocf_schema_v1",    "publisher": "Observable Compute Foundation",    "principal_contributors": [      {        "Author Name, Credential",        "Claude (Anthropic)"      },      {        "ein": "41-4747049",        "publication_date": "YYYY-MM",        "version": "N.N"      }    ],    "ocf_named_constructs": {      "readiness_stack": "...",      "pipeline_collapse": "...",      "rural_amplification_effect": "...",      "access_as_binding_constraint": "..."    },    "key_findings": [      {        "id": "F001",        "claim": "...",        "source": "...",        "confidence": 0.00      }    ]  }
```



8. Authorship and Contributions Format

OCF papers are published by the Observable Compute Foundation. Individual names do not appear on the cover or in running headers. Individual names appear only in the Authorship and Contributions note and in the JSON `paper_metadata`.

Standard authorship note format:

"This paper was published by the Observable Compute Foundation (EIN 41-4747049), a South Dakota nonprofit focused on workforce readiness and technology access. Principal contributors: [Name, credential] ([role description]) and [Name, credential] ([role description]). OCF is transparent about AI involvement in its research and publishing work. The analysis, editorial decisions, and OCF's programmatic framing are those of the Foundation."

The open licensing statement appears on the final line in Stone Gray: "[Year] Observable Compute Foundation. Open licensing. Cite with attribution."



Quick Reference: The Three Precision Rules

These three rules are the most commonly violated in non-compliant OCF documents. They are not obvious from reading the paper. They are only obvious from reading this guide.

§A Em Dash Prohibition (§4.2) ★ PRECISION RULE

No em dashes (—) anywhere. No exceptions. Restructure as new sentence or use a colon. A single em dash anywhere in a published OCF document indicates the author did not consult the style guide.

§B Citation Superscript Color (§5.1) ★ PRECISION RULE

All inline citation superscripts must render in OCF Ocean Blue (#1E5A78). Not black. Not gray. Not the default Word superscript color. #1E5A78 specifically. This is the single most reliable indicator that a document was built to the OCF standard rather than assembled in a word processor without compliance review.

§C Pull Quote Parity (§4.4) ★ PRECISION RULE

Each section containing pull quotes must contain an odd number of them. 1 is compliant. 3 is compliant. 2 is not. 4 is not. This is a deliberate visual rhythm standard and a document fingerprint. It has no other justification. It does not need one.